

Siding — Materials, Clearances and How They Fail

Every cladding material, what it is made of, and the distance it must keep from the ground.

Siding is a rain screen, not a seal. It sheds most of the water and expects the wall behind it to handle the rest, which is why the exam cares so much about clearances at the bottom: anything that touches wet ground wicks water upward and rots or spalls from below.

The numbers here

Wood siding above ground	6 in
Stucco weep screed above earth	4 in
Stucco weep screed above a paved surface	2 in
Fiber cement siding thickness	5/16 in
Vinyl siding nail head diameter	3/8 in

The weep screed has two numbers and both are correct

IRC R703.7.2.1 gives 4 inches above earth and 2 inches above a paved area. They are not alternatives — the surface underneath decides which applies. Your master number sheet lists only the 2.

The materials

Vinyl	The siding whose color is permeated throughout the material, so a scratch does not show a different color underneath. It is nailed loosely so it can expand and contract.
Fiber cement	A cement-based board, 5/16 inch thick.
Hardboard	Produced by bonding wood fibers together under heat and pressure.
Adhered stone	A combination of colored oxides, light aggregates and cement. It is a manufactured product stuck to the wall, not stone carrying its own weight.
House wrap	A weather-resistive barrier — and NOT a vapor barrier. It deliberately lets vapor pass so the wall can dry outward while stopping liquid water and air.

Paint

Flaking is caused by the alternate swelling and shrinkage of the siding underneath it. The paint film is more rigid than the wood it sits on, so when the wood moves with moisture the film loses its grip. Read a paint defect as a moisture story rather than a paint-quality story.

Say it back

Cover the page. Answer each one out loud.

1. Minimum ground clearance for wood siding?
2. Both weep screed numbers, and what decides which one applies?
3. Fiber cement thickness and vinyl nail head diameter?
4. Which siding has its color permeated throughout?
5. What is hardboard made from, and what is adhered stone made from?
6. Is house wrap a vapor barrier? Say why.
7. What causes paint to flake on siding?